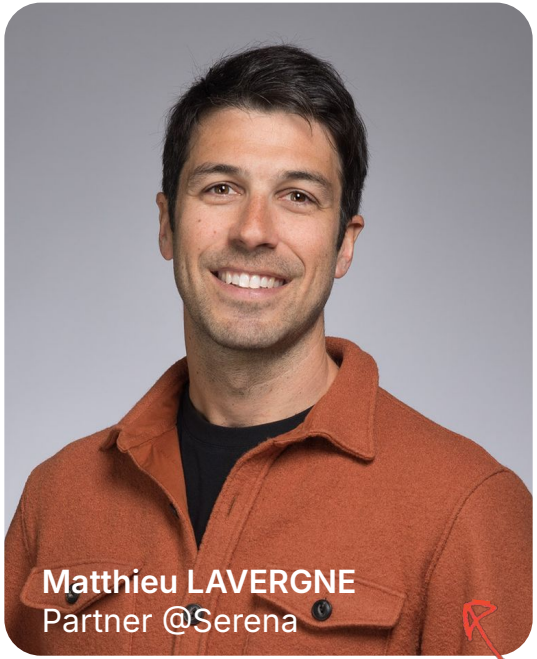
serena

COMMERCIAL OPEN SOURCE REPORT *2025*

25 years of data
on the *financial journey*
of Open Source companies

With the contribution of aws

WHY DID WE *BUILD* THIS REPORT?



IS OPEN SOURCE A GOOD FINANCIAL STRATEGY FOR ENTREPRENEURS AND INVESTORS?

For decades, the financial viability of Open Source has been a subject of debate. This report brings clarity by analyzing 25 years of data (2000–2024), tracking over 800 VC-backed COSS companies from their first funding to exit, and comparing them to closed-source software peers.

Over the past two decades, Open Source has redefined software adoption. Enterprises embrace Open Source to minimize vendor lock-in, enhance transparency, and take control of critical infrastructure. Developers prefer it for its flexibility, security through community scrutiny, and the ability to contribute directly to the tools they rely on.

Yet, the financial case for Open Source businesses remains contested.

Conventional wisdom suggests that COSS startups struggle with value capture, differentiation, and competition from cloud providers who commercialize Open Source through managed services.

However, the data tells a different story. While some dismiss Red Hat's $34B sale, HashiCorp's $6.4B acquisition, and MongoDB's $30B+ valuation as outliers, this report demonstrates that **these successes are part of a repeatable financial pattern—especially in infrastructure software**.

The evidence is clear: **COSS companies raise capital faster, achieve higher valuations, exit at stronger multiples, and deliver superior shareholder returns** compared to closed-source peers.

By providing a data-backed perspective, this report aims to defy skepticism and offer investors, founders, and operators a deeper understanding of the financial realities of Commercial Open Source.

DEFINITION

METHODOLOGY

800+
VC-BACKED COSS COMPANIES

25 YEARS OF DATA

FROM 1st VC ROUND TO EXIT

This report draws on 25 years of venture data (2000-2024), tracking over 800 VC-backed COSS companies globally. We follow these companies from the first VC round to exit (M&A or IPO) and benchmark their trajectories against a control group of closed-source software companies, normalized for founding year, geography, and sector.

In this report, “Open Source” is defined broadly. It covers companies whose products rely on publicly accessible source code—whether under an OSI-approved license, open weights in AI, or products with a meaningful open-source component alongside proprietary features. This reflects the evolving reality of COSS models in today’s software landscape.

The analysis integrates quantitative financing and exit data (from PitchBook) with open-source activity data (from GitHub), giving us a combined view of financial performance and community traction. This dual perspective allows us to assess whether community engagement meaningfully influences financing success and valuation, and how COSS performance compares head-to-head with proprietary software across funding, growth, and exit outcomes.

Special thanks to the main contributors to that report on the Serena Team including **Emma Guetta**, **Antoine Giacomini**, **Kyle Le Bris Saget** and **Juliette Ast**.

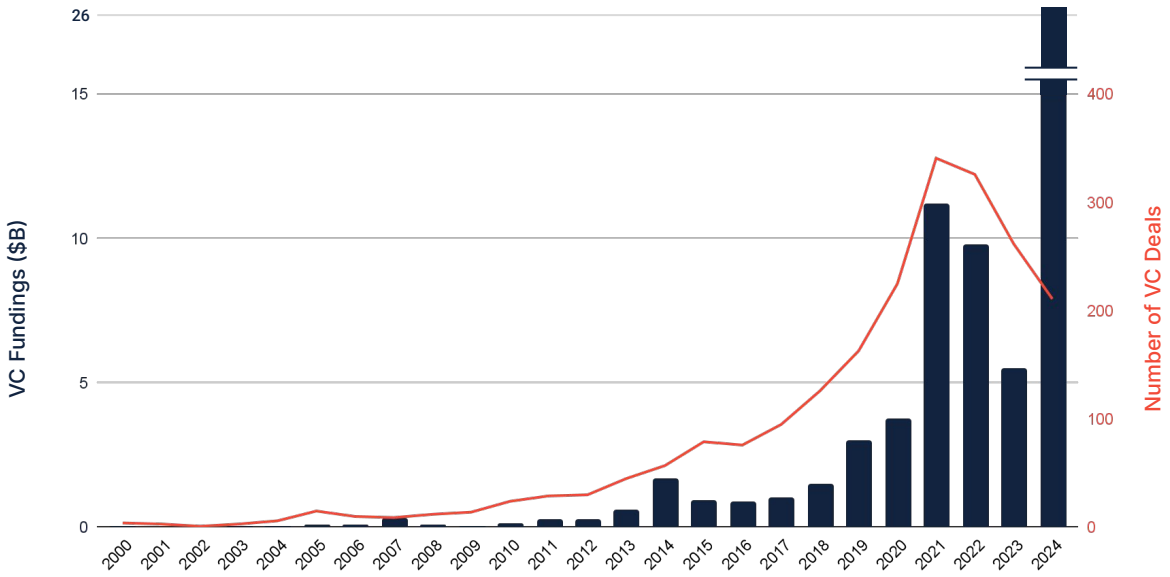
PART *01*

COMMERCIAL OPEN SOURCE AS A *VC CATEGORY*

Q: HOW BIG IS THE COSS VC CATEGORY?

THERE HAVE BEEN *211 VC DEALS* IN COSS IN 2024 TOTALLING *$26.4B* IN AGGREGATE FUNDING

Yearly Deal Count and VC Funding in COSS



~250 Deal per year [19 - 24]

4.5% Of all software VC investments [24]

~$9B VC Fundings per Year [19 - 24]

Source: Pitchbook Data

Q: WHAT ARE THE BIGGEST ROUNDS OF 2024 IN COSS?

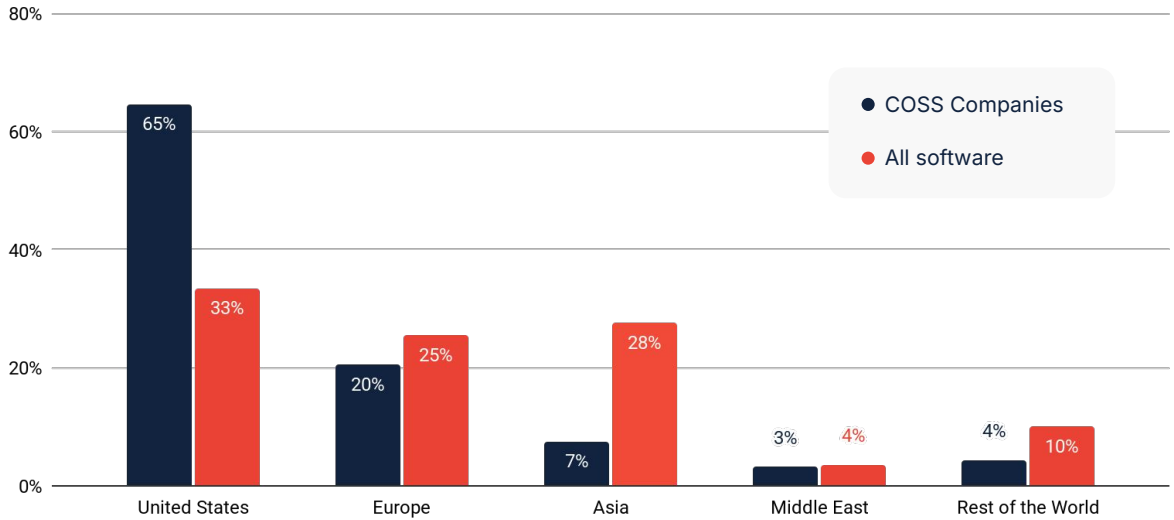
THE BIGGEST COSS *FUNDRAISING ROUNDS* IN 2024

COMPANIES	DEAL SIZE ($M)	DEAL DATE	VERTICALS
databricks	9,500	Dec. 2024	AI
xAI	5,585	Nov. 2024	AI
xAI	5,561	May 2024	AI
tenstorrent	659	Dec. 2024	AI
MISTRAL AI_	600	June 2024	AI
MISTRAL AI_	399	Feb. 2024	AI
Grafana	300	Aug. 2024	Observability
Vercel	233	May 2024	CloudTech & DevOps
Rivos	321	Apr. 2024	Semiconductors
aqua	178	Jan. 2024	Cybersecurity, SaaS, TMT

Source: Pitchbook Data

THE US IS THE PRIMARY HUB FOR VC-BACKED COSS COMPANIES, WHERE THEY ARE *DISPROPORTIONATELY* REPRESENTED

Headquarters Location (% of total) by region



Source: Pitchbook Data

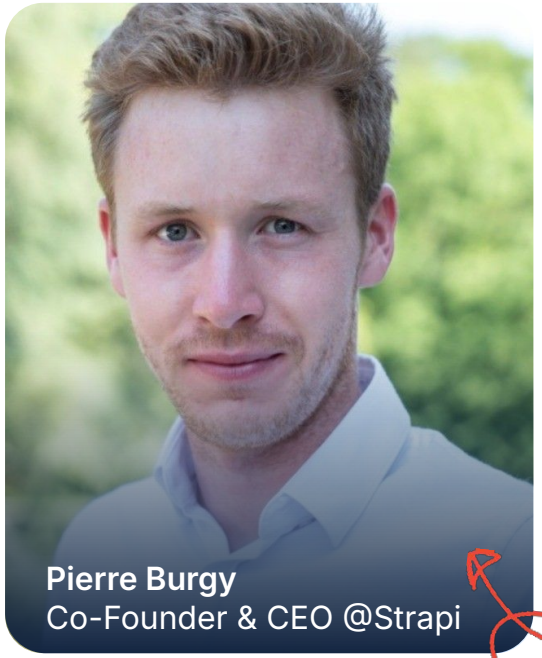
COSS companies are far more concentrated in the US (65%) than the overall software industry (33%), highlighting the US as the dominant hub for Commercial Open Source innovation.

Europe has a stronger presence in COSS (20%) compared to its share of the overall software sector (25%), suggesting a growing ecosystem for open-source businesses.

Asia, despite being a major software hub (27.5%), has a much smaller share of COSS companies (7.5%), indicating lower adoption of open-source business models.

TESTIMONIAL

THE POV



Pierre Burgy
Co-Founder & CEO @Strapi

strapi

HQ: USA

Cum. Fundings: ~$50M

Ten years ago, securing VC funding for open-source startups in Europe was almost impossible—the ecosystem simply wasn't mature enough, and investors lacked the appetite for such risk.

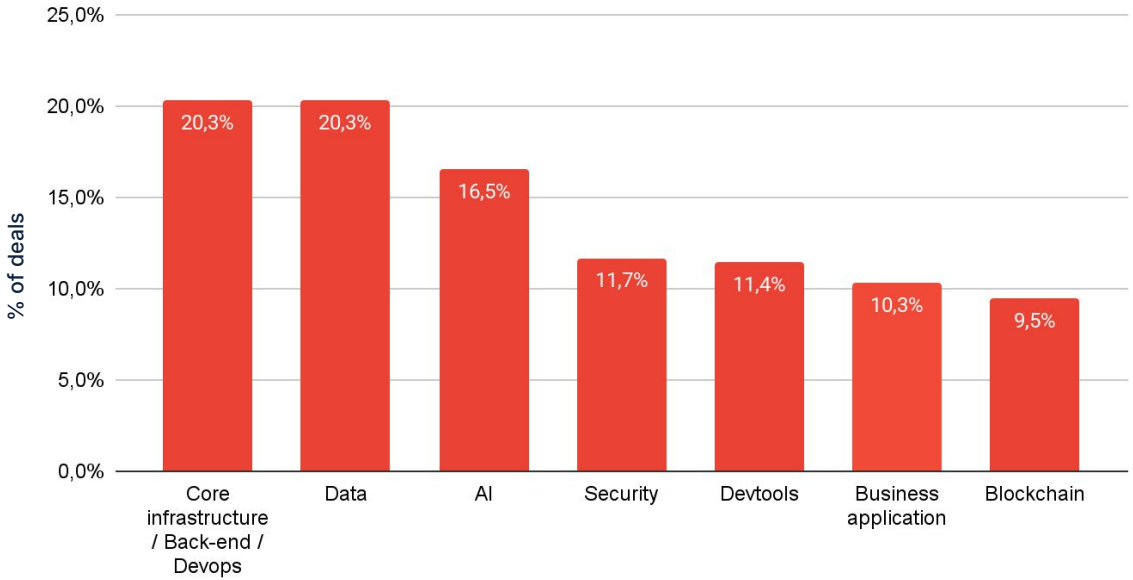
Thankfully, the landscape has changed for the better. Tech European VCs now support open-source ventures at early stages. However, at later funding rounds, founders inevitably must still seek US investors, as Europe lacks sufficient depth of late-stage capital.

Commercial Open Source Software (COSS) companies are inherently international from day one because their products are globally accessible. And given that roughly 50% of the Software total addressable market sits in the US, it's essential to build a meaningful US presence early—first to drive user adoption, then to scale sales.

Recently, as US investors pull back from European markets, establishing a physical presence in the US is increasingly vital to secure American capital and maintain competitive growth.

VCs INVEST IN *OPEN SOURCE COMPANIES* THAT FORM THE BACKBONE OF MODERN SOFTWARE & CLOUD ECOSYSTEMS

Deal count (% of total) per categories



Methodology: We categorized companies into 7 segments using a mix of PitchBook descriptions and automated classification via GPT API, run 5 times per company with a majority vote to ensure consistency.

Core Infrastructure and Data Lead: Each category represents 20% of deals, showing that investors focus on foundational open-source technologies that enable cloud computing, data management, and large-scale software operations.

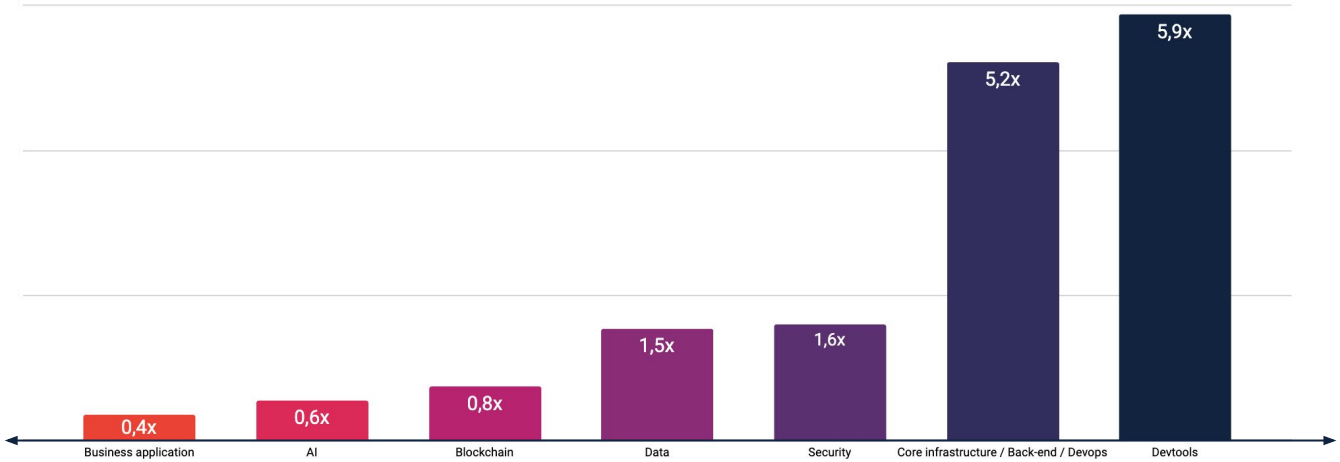
AI Gains Strong Traction (17%), reflecting the increasing role of open-source AI frameworks and models in automation, analytics, and machine learning.

Security (12%) and DevTools (11%) Remain Key Areas, highlighting sustained interest in cybersecurity solutions and developer productivity tools.

Lower Investment in Business Applications (10%) and Blockchain (9%), suggesting that open-source adoption in enterprise software and decentralized technologies is not as mature as in infrastructure-related segments.

DEVTOOLS & CORE INFRASTRUCTURE COMPANIES ARE *FAR MORE LIKELY* TO GO OPEN SOURCE THAN CLOSED SOURCE

Odds ratio for a given company to be COSS Companies vs. Closed Source



More likely to go Closed Source

More likely to go Open Source

Methodology: We calculated the odds ratio for each software category by comparing the share of COSS companies within that category to the overall share of COSS companies in a combined dataset of US software companies founded after 2018, VC-backed, using PitchBook data with COSS companies removed from the control group.

THE POV



Rand Hindi
Co-Founder & CEO @Zama

ZAMA

HQ: France

Cum. Fundings: ~$110M

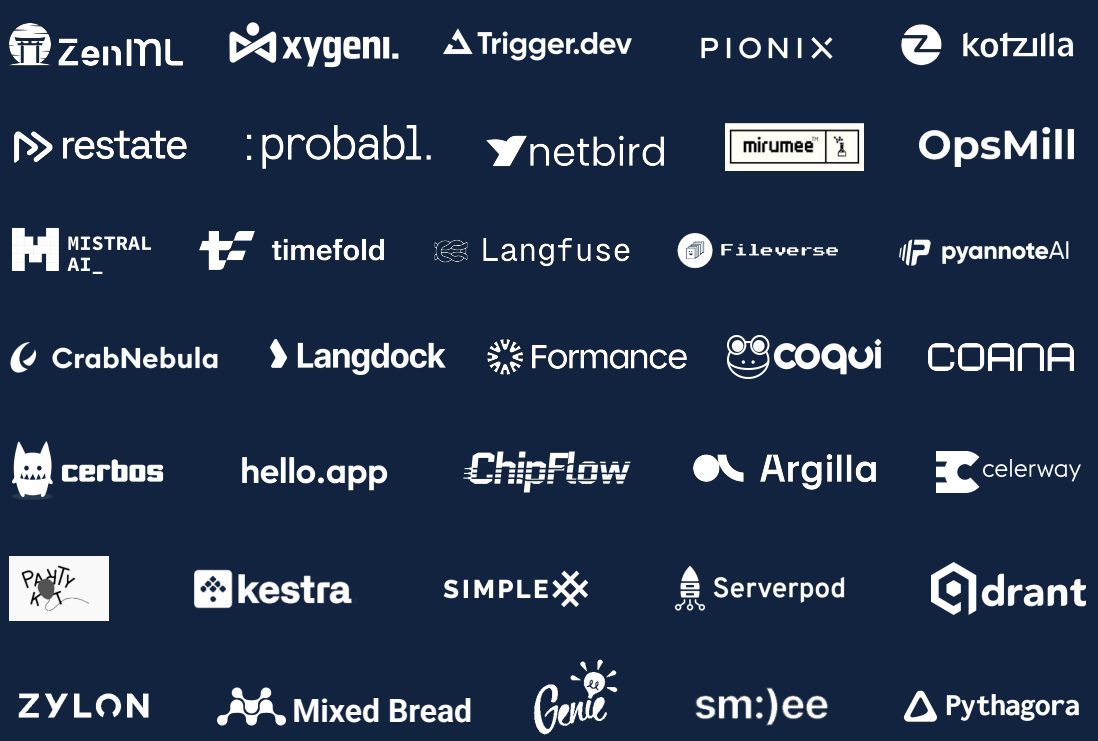
As a cryptography company, we had no choice but to fully open source our technology to gain trust and adoption.

However, this raised a key question: how could we maintain defensibility against large companies that had superior distribution, resources, and product capabilities? Competing on those fronts alone was not an option, so we implemented a dual licensing strategy.

We open-sourced our core technology while filing patents to prevent direct replication. At the same time, we focused on capturing and retaining key talent—ensuring that by the time competitors found ways to work around our patents, we would have already built a strong distribution network and significant brand equity.

EUROPEAN *COSS COMPANIES* TO KEEP TRACK OF

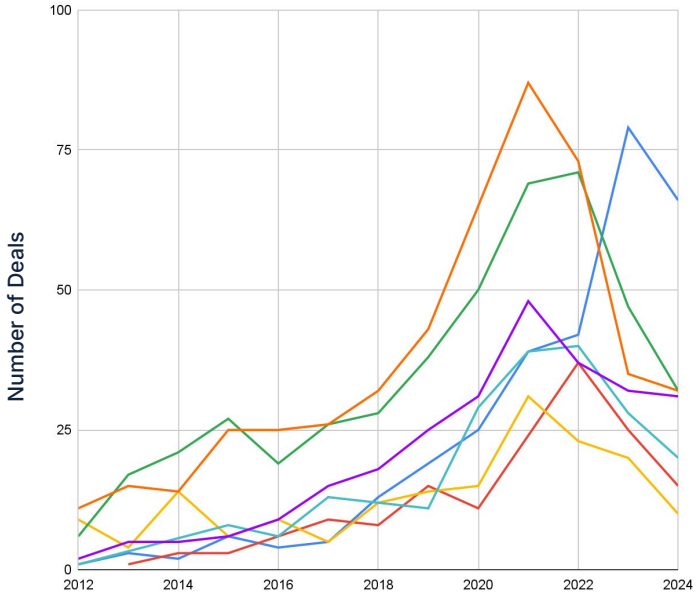
Selection criteria:
Stage: Seed
Round Size: Minimum $1M
Year of Creation: 2023 or 2024



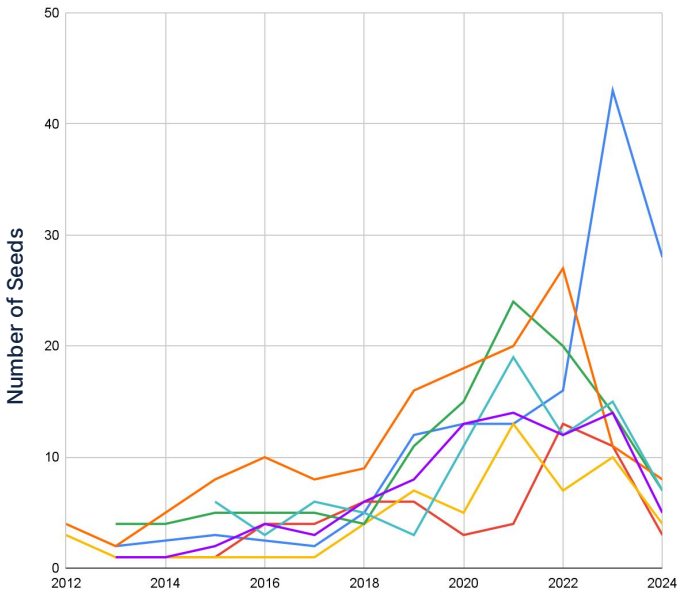
Source: Pitchbook Data

IN 2024, AI SECURED ITS PLACE IN THE *COSS UNIVERSE*

Deal Count per category



Seed Round: Deal Count per category



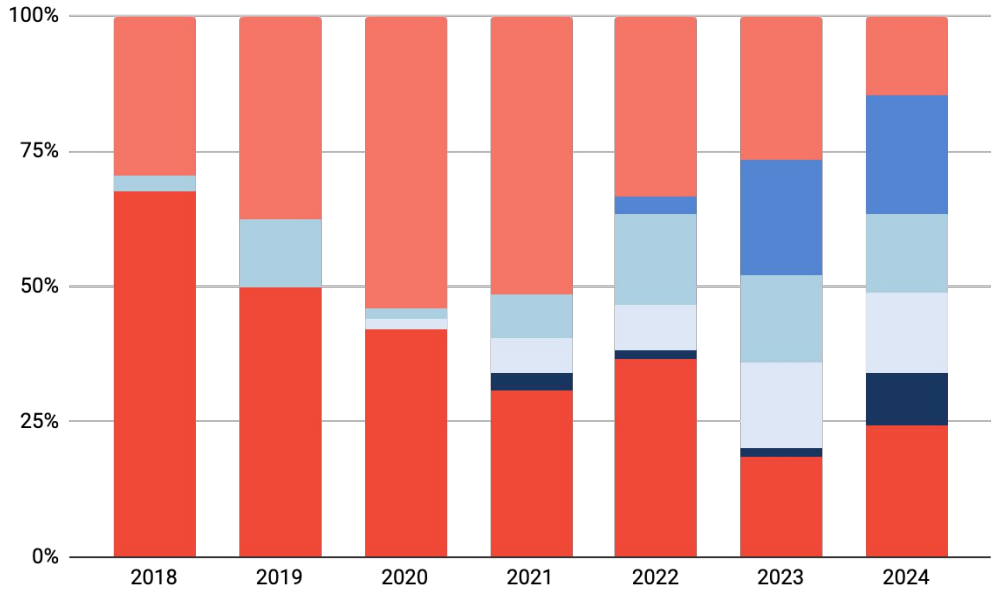
Categories

- AI
- Blockchain
- Business Application
- Data
- Devtools
- Security
- Core Infrastructure, Back-end, Devops

Source: Pitchbook Data

NEARLY HALF OF AI MODELS RELEASED HAVE INCLUDED SOME FORM OF *OPEN COMPONENT*—THOUGH THE DEFINITION OF 'OPEN' REMAINS *AMBIGUOUS*

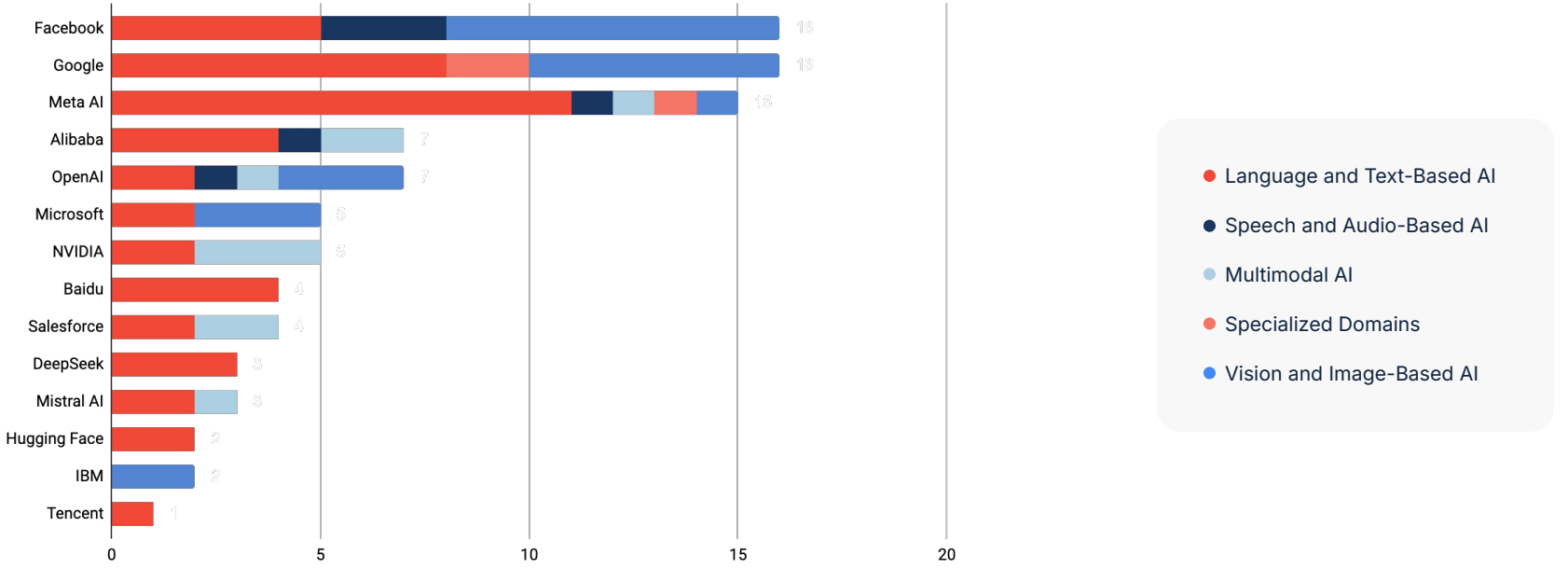
Most notable AI models released from 2019 to 2024



Source: Epoch AI Data, How Far Behind Are Open Models?

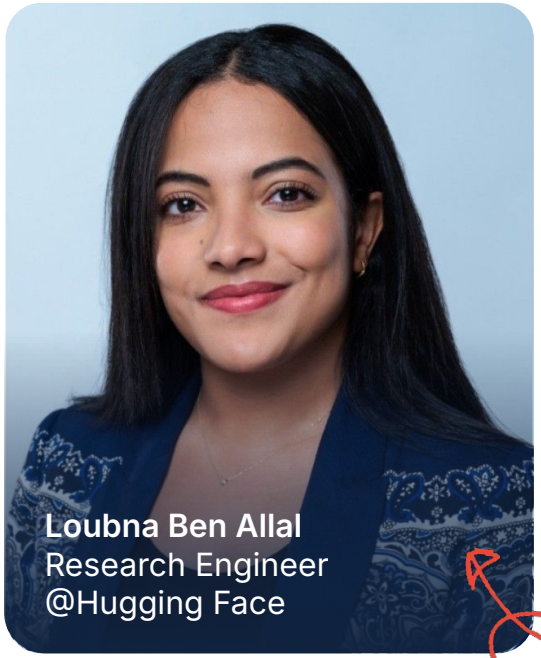
OPEN-WEIGHT AI: BIG TECH *CALLS* THE SHOTS ON 'OPENNESS'

Specialization of Organization in Open Weight / Source AI Models



Source: Epoch AI Data, How Far Behind Are Open Models? Only models classified as Open Weights (Unrestricted), Open Weights (Restricted Use), and Open Weights (Non-Commercial) were included.

THE POV



Hugging Face **HQ:** USA **Cum. Fundings:** ~$400M

Openly released AI models often spark community-driven innovation.

Over 1.5 million public models are now available on Hugging Face, with some attracting millions of monthly users.

More notably, active users don't just adopt these models — they build on top of them, extending their impact and reach. That kind of adoption compounds visibility, usefulness, and ultimately, trust in the original model — which feeds directly back into the brand.

In foundational models, open-source creates a compounding trust loop: transparency accelerates adoption, and community scrutiny enhances robustness. We've seen this firsthand — releasing open weights brought not just traction, but credibility in a highly competitive space.

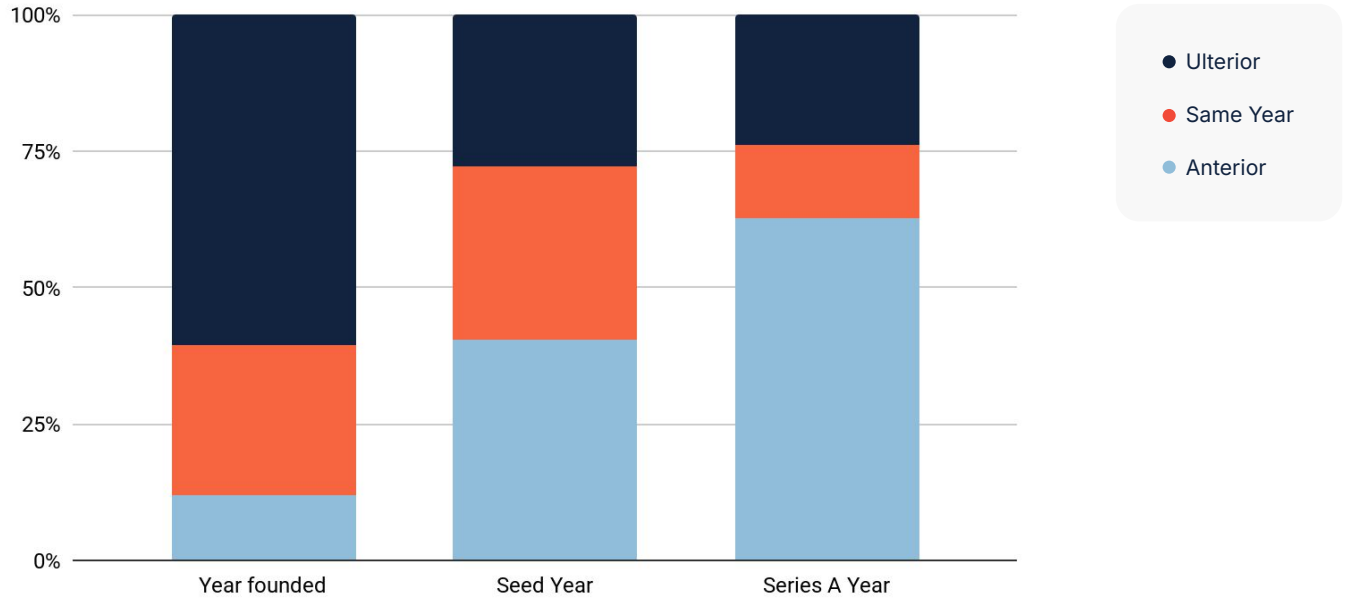
While it's easy to worry that openness limits defensibility, we've learned that in a fast-moving field like AI, community trust and contribution can be far more durable than a secret sauce.

PART *02*

THE VC JOURNEY FOR *COSS COMPANIES*

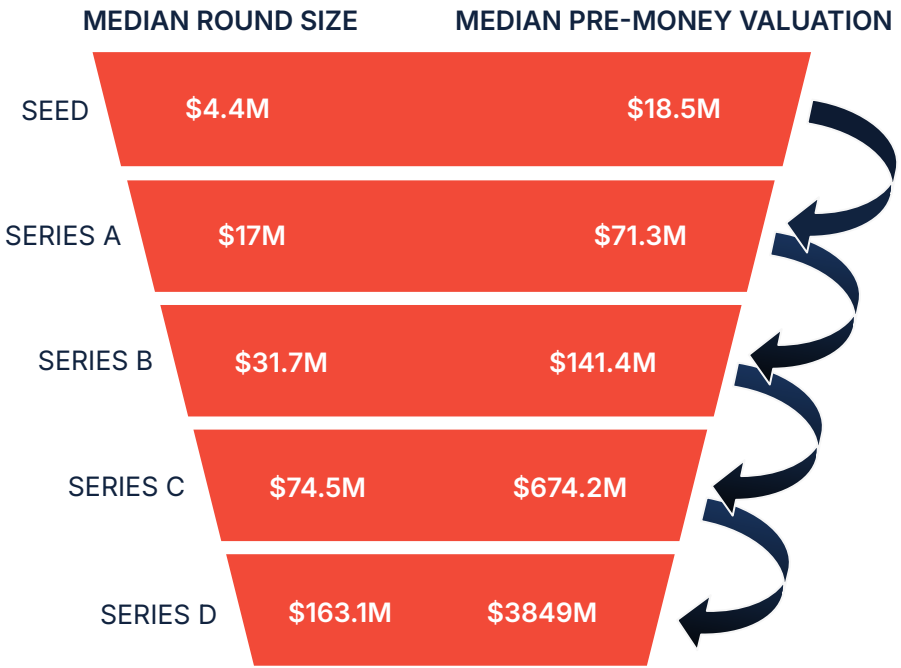
MOST COSS COMPANIES LAUNCH BEFORE THEIR *FIRST REPO* IS RELEASED

Timing for Repository release



Methodology: Based on PitchBook and GitHub data, we compared the creation year of the official organization repository with the company's founding year, Seed round year, and Series A round year. The GitHub page used is the company's current official organization page. Some projects may have originally started on a personal developer account before being migrated to the official company repo.

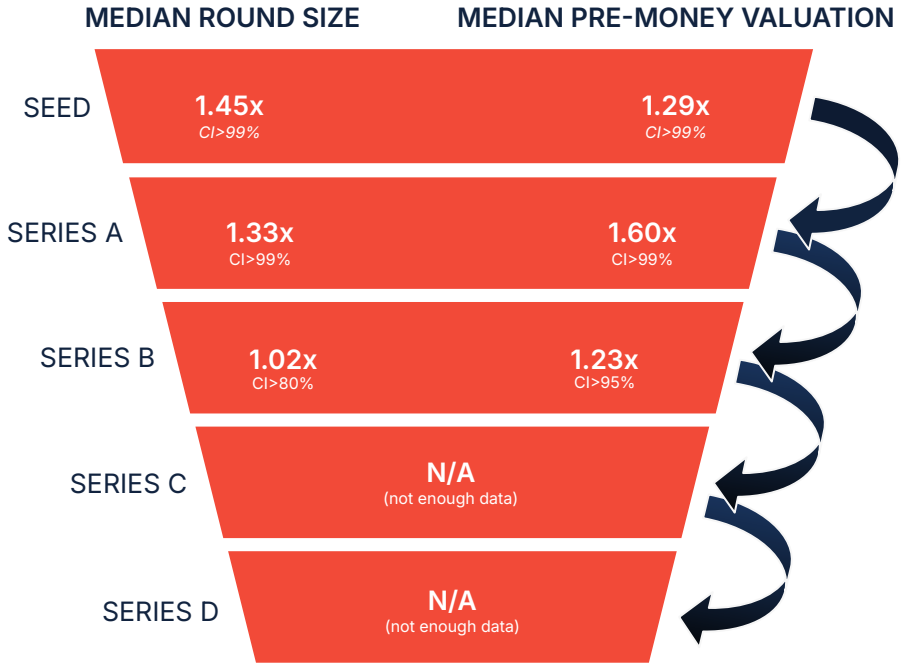
THE TYPICAL *VC JOURNEY* FOR COSS COMPANIES



TIME BETWEEN ROUNDS	CONVERSION RATE
15 months	74%
17 months	62%
17 months	61%
13 months	54%

Methodology: Round sizes and valuations were calculated on a 2023-2024 cohort. Conversion rates were calculated on a 2015-2017 seed cohort. Median lead times were calculated across all companies in the sample.

COSS COMPANIES RAISE MORE CAPITAL, FASTER, AND WITH GREATER EASE THAN THEIR *CLOSED-SOURCE COUNTERPARTS*



	TIME BETWEEN ROUNDS	CONVERSION RATE
SEED	20% Faster *CI>99%*	91% Higher CI>99%
SERIES A	34% Faster CI>80%	88% Higher CI>98.5%
SERIES B	None (not enough data)	None (not enough data)
SERIES C	None (not enough data)	None (not enough data)

CI = Confidence Interval

Methodology: Round sizes, valuations, and time between rounds were calculated on a 2018-2024 cohort (US, software, VC-backed), comparing COSS companies to a matched control group with similar sector distribution; conversion rates were calculated on a 2015-2017 seed cohort, with all metrics based on PitchBook data and statistical significance assessed across 100 resampled control groups.

TESTIMONIAL

THE POV



ClickHouse **HQ:** USA **Cum. Fundings:** ~$300M

Adopting new software in a company is a multi-step journey, and open source has been instrumental in driving the success of ClickHouse Cloud at every stage. The most crucial step, adoption, becomes significantly easier with open source.

Technical teams can seamlessly download, install, and experiment with the software without external friction, enabling rapid proof-of-concept validation. From there, assessing the software's value and moving to production is a natural progression, with minimal barriers.

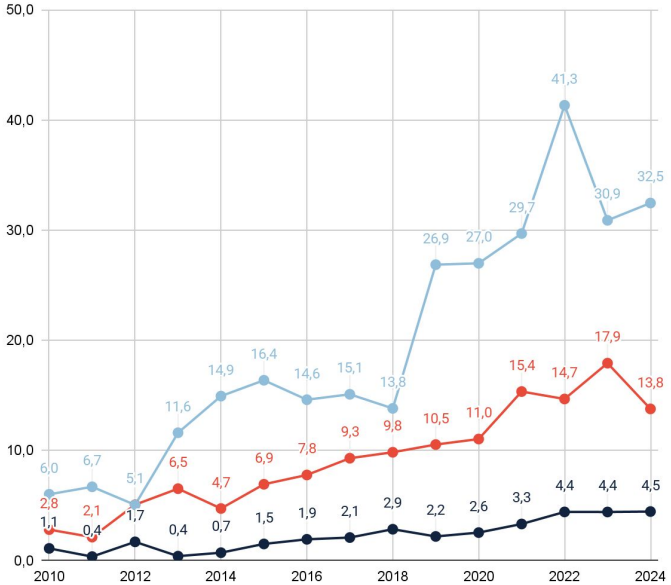
Beyond adoption, building in the open let us kick off new features as quickly as possible, polish product quality, and receive feedback as soon as possible.

Open source is the strongest marketing and distribution force, organically expanding our user base and market reach. As ClickHouse's popularity grows, so does the demand for our commercial offering. And because our cloud service is built on the same open-source foundation, transitioning from OSS to a commercial solution is frictionless.

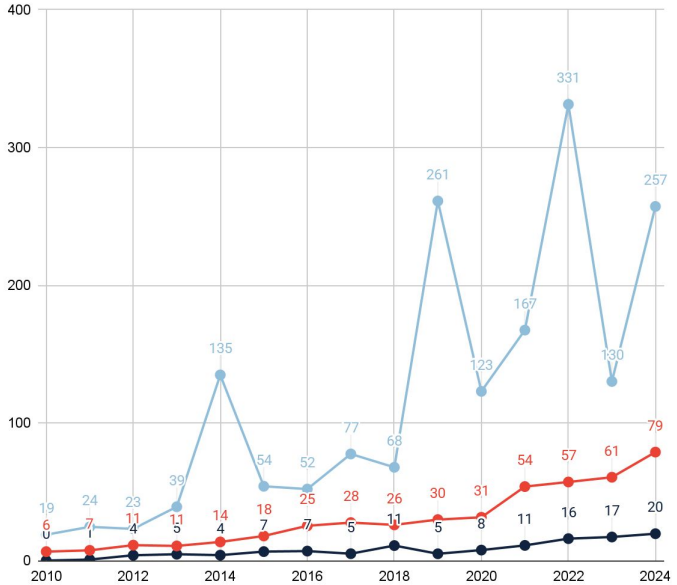
The enterprise offering further extends the value with scalability, security, integrations, and compliance—ensuring that open source fuels, rather than competes with, commercial success.

THE SIZE OF FUNDRAISING ROUNDS FOR COSS IS INCREASING, MIRRORING *THE OVERALL TREND* IN VC FUNDRAISING

Median Round Sizes in COSS



Median Pre-money valuation in COSS



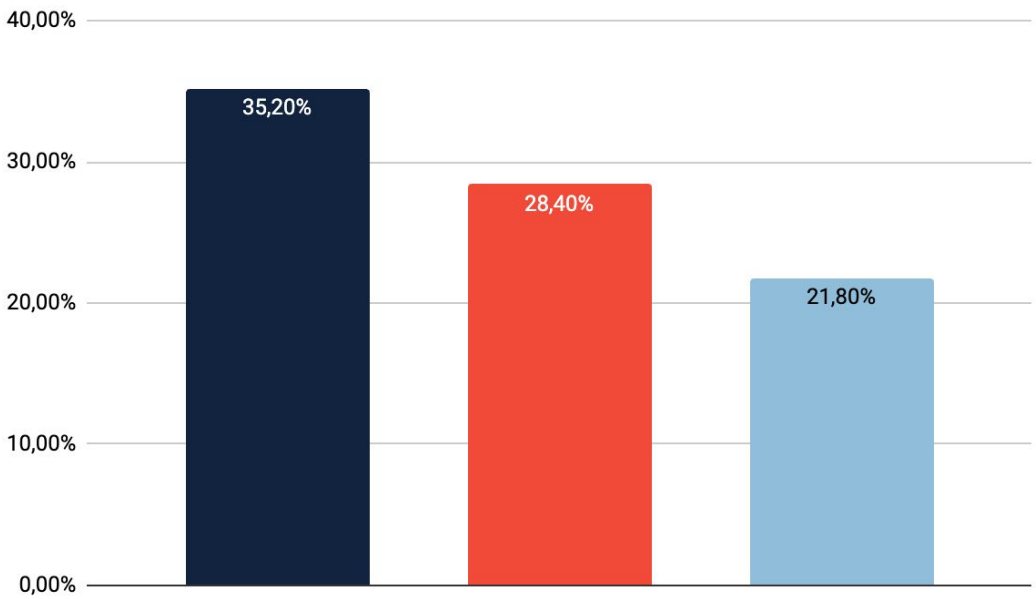
Deal Type

- Seed Round
- Series A
- Series B

Source: PitchBook Data

COSS COMPANIES CAN *SECURE FUNDINGS*, EVEN IN LATER ROUNDS, WITH LITTLE TO NO COMMUNITY TRACTION

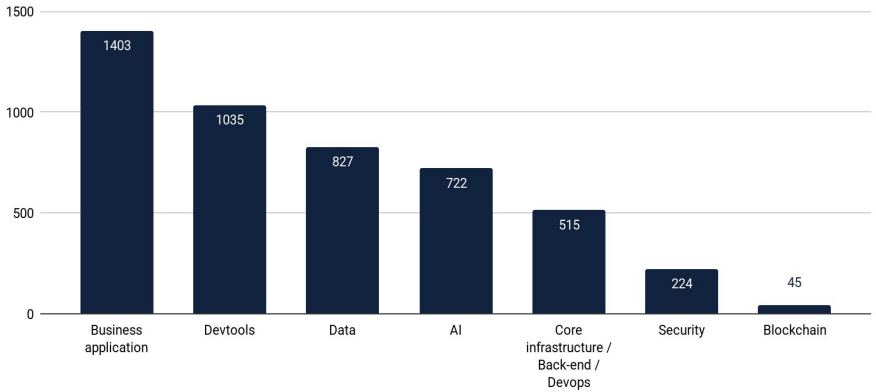
% of companies that raise with less than 100 GitHub stars



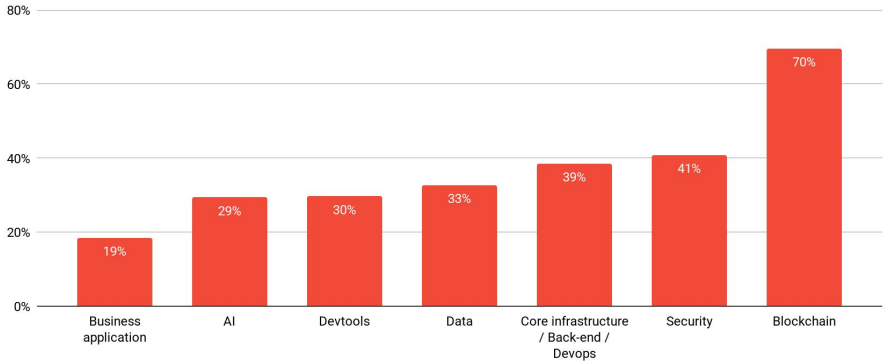
Methodology: PitchBook and GitHub Data. We look at the most starred repo at the time of the fundraising event.

FOR BUSINESS APPS, DEVTOOLS, AND DATA, COMMUNITY TRACTION MATTERS—BUT ONLY *SLIGHTLY*

Median of repos stars at seed time per category

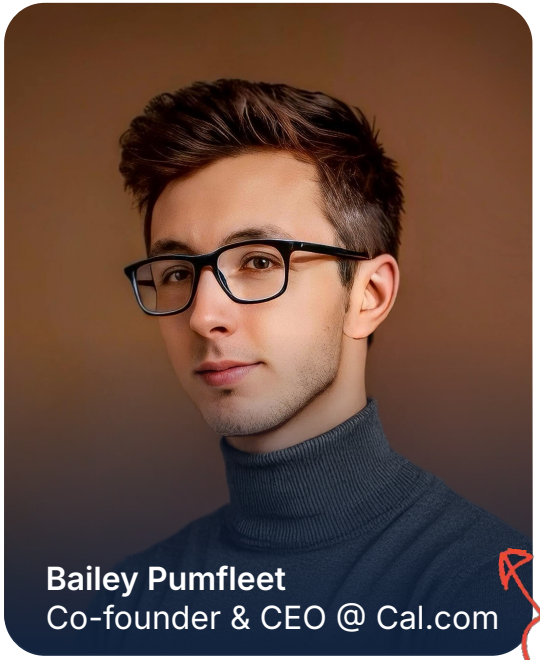


% of projects with fewer than 100 stars per category (Seed Round)



Methodology: We used data from PitchBook cross-referenced with GitHub data on repository stars. Specifically, we analyzed the stars of the most popular repository on the company's GitHub page at the time of fundraising.

THE POV



Bailey Pumfleet
Co-founder & CEO @ Cal.com

Cal.com | **HQ:** USA | **Cum. Fundings:** ~$30M

When we started Cal.com, choosing open source wasn't about differentiating ourselves from closed-source competitors—it aligned naturally with our vision and infrastructure approach.

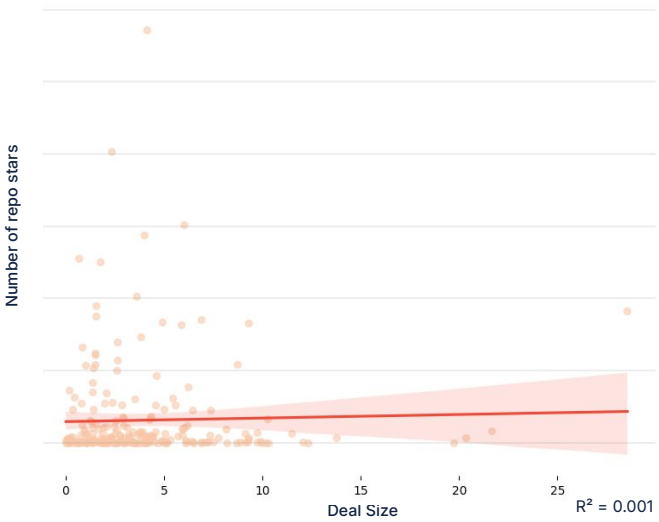
Open source alone doesn't automatically set you apart; it must directly reinforce your core value proposition to truly differentiate.

Fundraising wasn't an issue for us—the open source aspect didn't raise eyebrows since investors cared primarily about the health and potential of our business model, which we had. Yes, there's always someone who might copy your code, but that's precisely where building a strong brand matters.

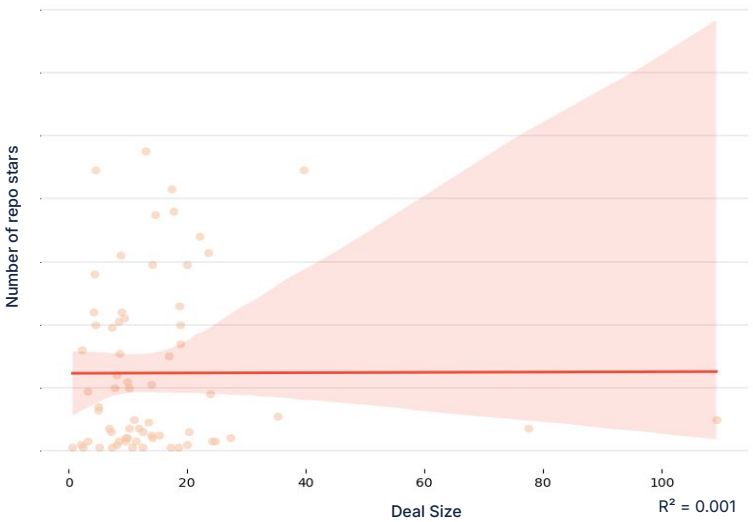
Beyond this, we've seen significant downstream benefits in the sales process, particularly in compliance, privacy, and extensibility. These advantages have positioned Cal.com as a compelling case study in the commercial open source space.

COMMUNITY TRACTION DOESN'T TRANSLATE TO LARGER *FUNDING ROUNDS* FOR COSS COMPANIES

Seed Round: Star Count vs Deal Size



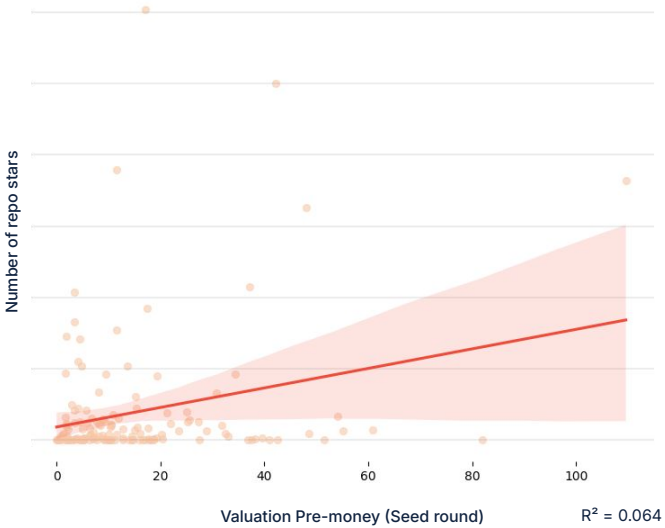
Series A: Star Count vs Deal Size



Methodology: We used data from PitchBook (2022–2024), cross-referenced with GitHub data on repository stars. Specifically, we analyzed the stars of the most popular repository on the company's GitHub page at the time of fundraising.

AT SEED, COMMUNITY TRACTION MAY BOOST VALUATIONS FOR COSS COMPANIES BUT HAS LITTLE IMPACT IN *LATER ROUNDS*

Seed Round: Star Count vs Pre-money Valuation



Series A: Star Count vs Pre-money Valuation

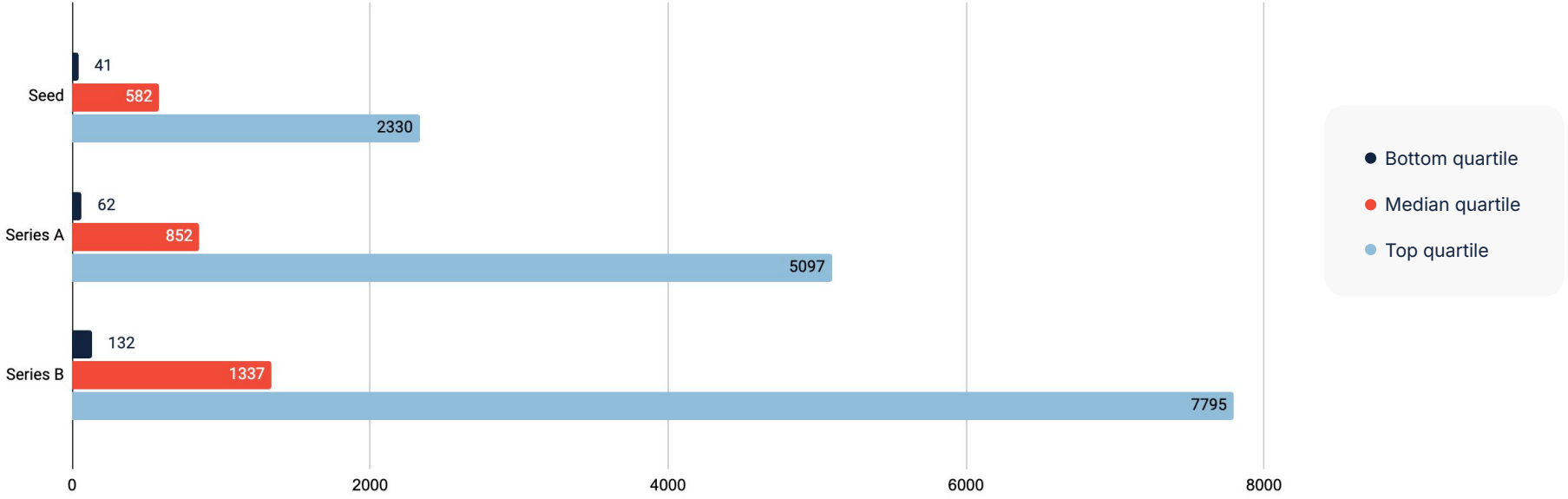


For seed rounds, the graph shows a weak positive correlation between post-deal valuation (Seed Round) and the number of stars, with significant variability and a wide margin of uncertainty, suggesting other factors may play a major role.

Methodology: We used data from PitchBook (2022–2024), cross-referenced with Git Archives data on repository stars. Specifically, we analyzed the stars of the most popular repository on the company's GitHub page at the time of fundraising.

GITHUB *STARS* FUNDRAISING BENCHMARK

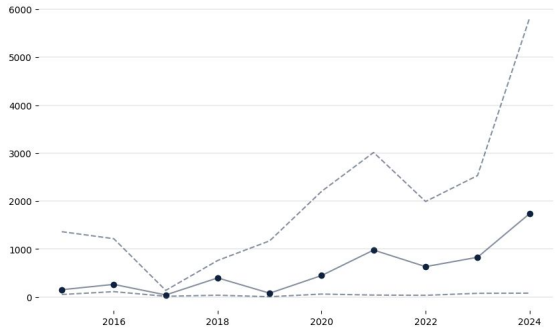
Number of Stars (at the time of the fundraising)



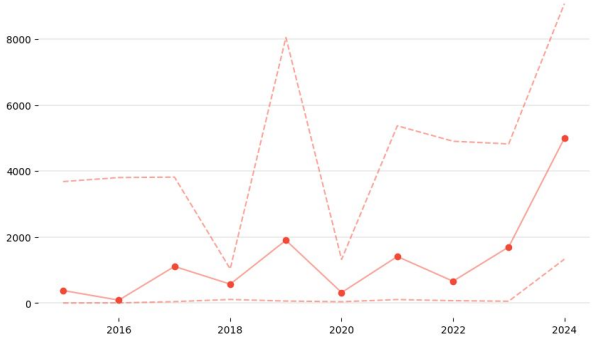
Methodology: We used data from PitchBook (2015–2024), cross-referenced with Git Archives data on repository stars. Specifically, we analyzed the stars of the most popular repository on the company's GitHub page at the time of fundraising.

VC BACKED COSS COMPANIES ARE GETTING BETTER AT BUILDING *THEIR COMMUNITIES*

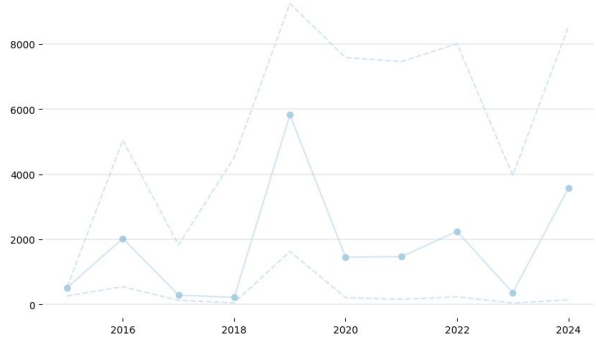
Number of stars over time per Deal Type



Seed Round



Series A



Series B

● Median --- 25e & 75e Pct

GitHub stars have increased at fundraising events from 2016 to 2024, reflecting either growing VC focus on GitHub traction or greater adoption of open-source projects by users

Methodology: PitchBook and GitHub Data. Most starred repo.

TESTIMONIAL

THE POV



Bob Van Luijt
Co-founder & CEO @Weaviate

Weaviate **HQ:** Netherlands **Cum. Fundings:** ~$62M

At Weaviate, we've seen how open source plays very different roles depending on your stage.

Pre-revenue, OSS is all about building a great product and a recognizable brand fast. Your metrics substitute for revenue—so long as you measure what matters, not vanity metrics. It's about driving usage and adoption first. Post-revenue, OSS metrics shift from a revenue substitute to fueling GTM; they become a top-of-funnel driver.

In the end, with closed source, you eat the whole pie—but it's often smaller. With open source, you only eat a slice, but if your product, funnel, and brand are strong, the pie and the slice can be 10x larger.

PART *03*

LIQUIDITY AND SHAREHOLDER ROI IN *COSS*

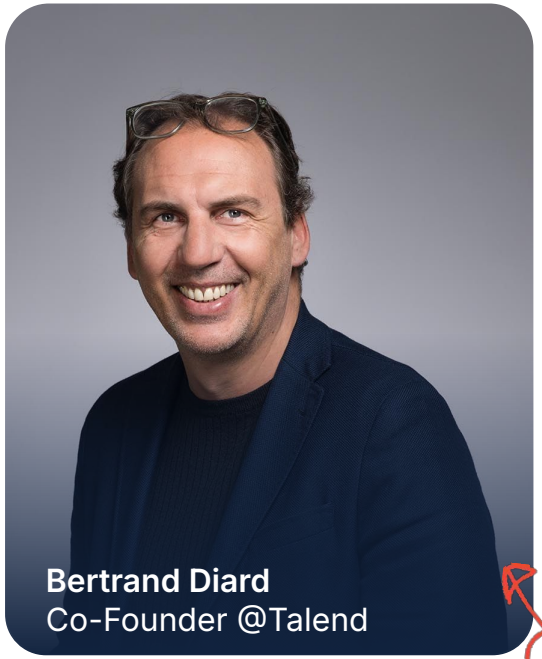
COSS EXITS ARE REAL: 12% OF COSS COMPANIES THAT ENTERED THE *VC FUNNEL* HAVE REACHED M&A OR IPO STAGES



Source: PitchBook Data

TESTIMONIAL

THE POV



Bertrand Diard
Co-Founder @Talend

talend

HQ: France

NASDAQ IPO in 2016
taken Private in 2021

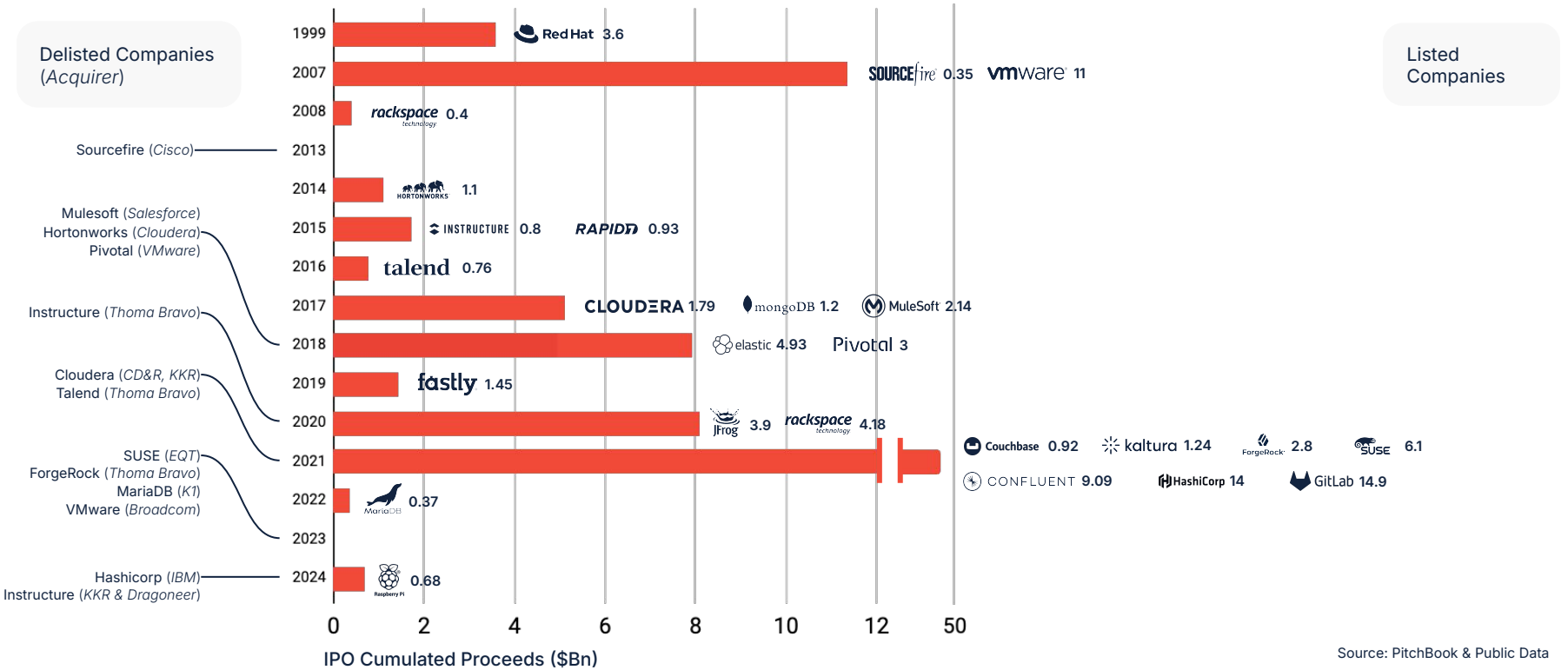
There's a persistent myth that liquidity is harder to achieve for Open Source companies. But that's the wrong framing altogether.

Liquidity doesn't depend on being Open Source or not—it depends on being a great company.

Once you've reached scale and profitability, you're no longer seen as an 'Open Source business'—you're simply a software company.

At that point, public markets and acquirers look at the same metrics they would for any SaaS or infrastructure player: revenue growth, gross margins, profitability, capital efficiency. The open source label may describe your origin, but it doesn't define your exit.

HISTORY OF ALL VC-BACKED COSS COMPANIES REACHING IPO OVER THE LAST 25 YEARS

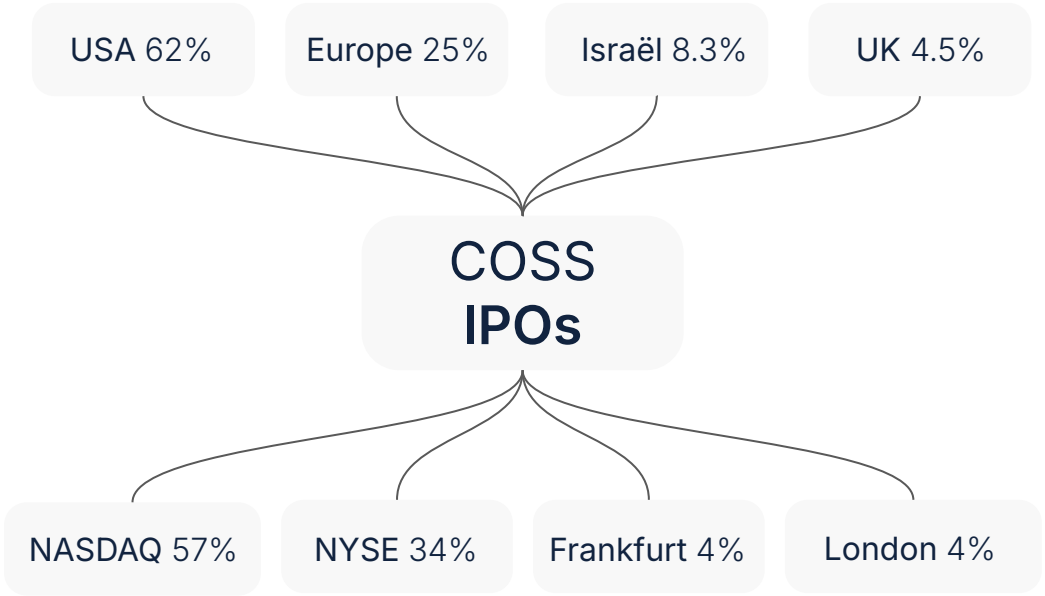


Source: PitchBook & Public Data

Q: WHERE DID COSS PUBLIC COMPANIES ORIGINATE AND GET LISTED?

US-BORN (62%) & EU-BORN (25%) COMPANIES PROVIDE THE *BULK* OF THE *IPO SUPPLY*. US STOCK EXCHANGES RECEIVED 91% OF IPOs

Country of Origin (% of total IPOs)

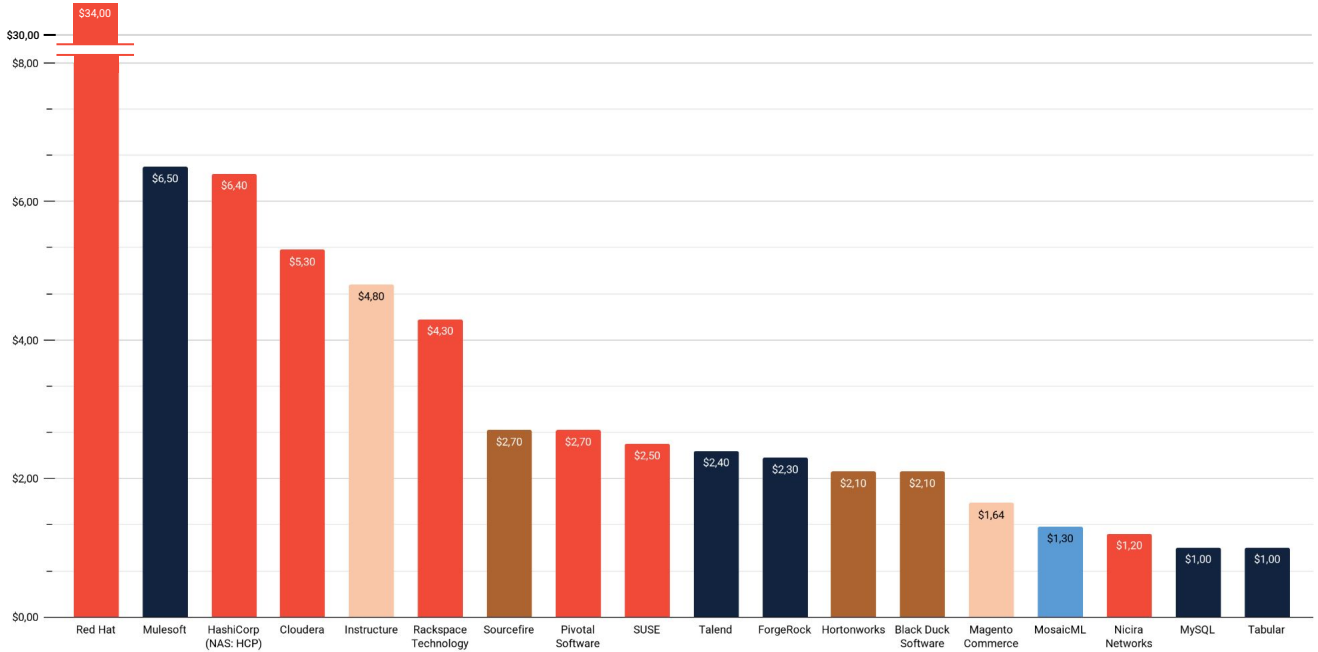


Stock Markets (% of total IPOs)

Source: PitchBook Data

THE BIGGEST M&A COSS *DEALS* SINCE 2000

Top Biggest COSS M&A Deals in history ($Bn)



Source: Pitchbook and Public Data

Categories

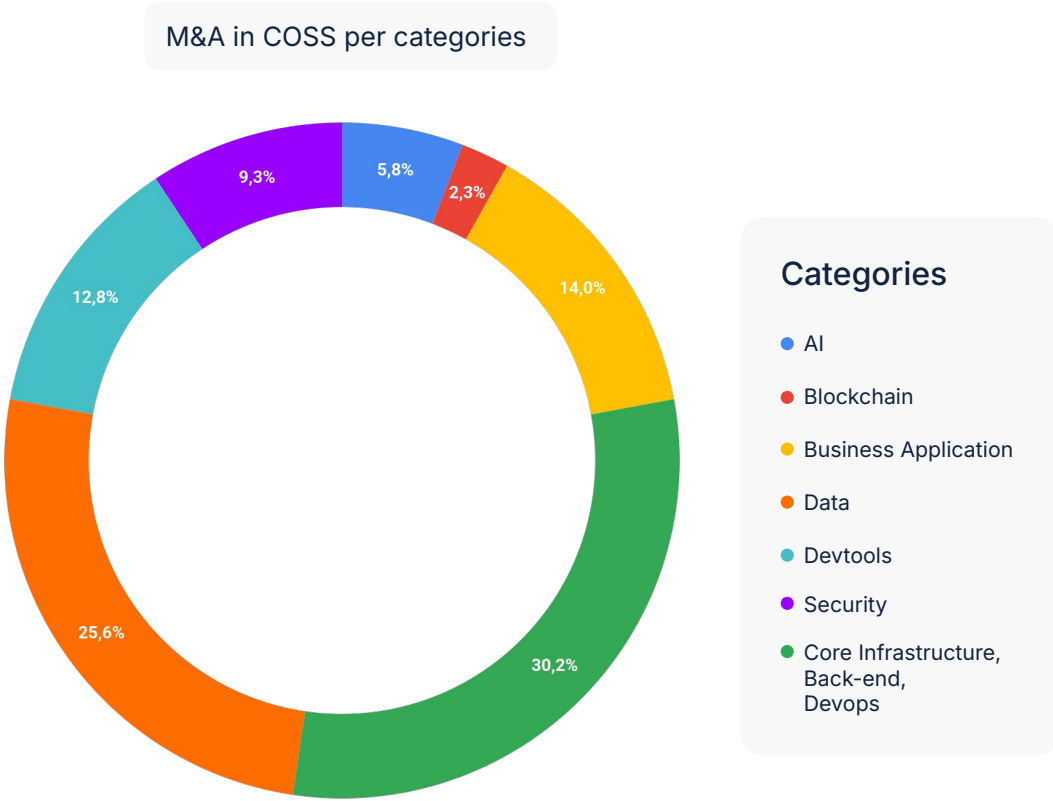
- Business Application
- Data
- AI
- Security
- Core Infrastructure, Back-end, Devops

Q: WHAT TYPE OF COMPANIES GET ACQUIRED HISTORICALLY?

55%

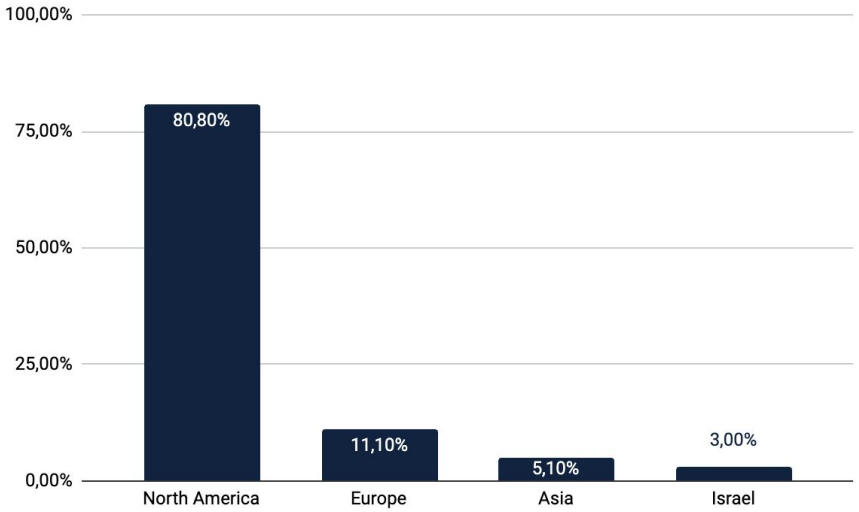
OF COSS *M&A ACTIVITY* OCCURRED IN CORE INFRASTRUCTURE & DATA TOOLS

Source: PitchBook & Public Data

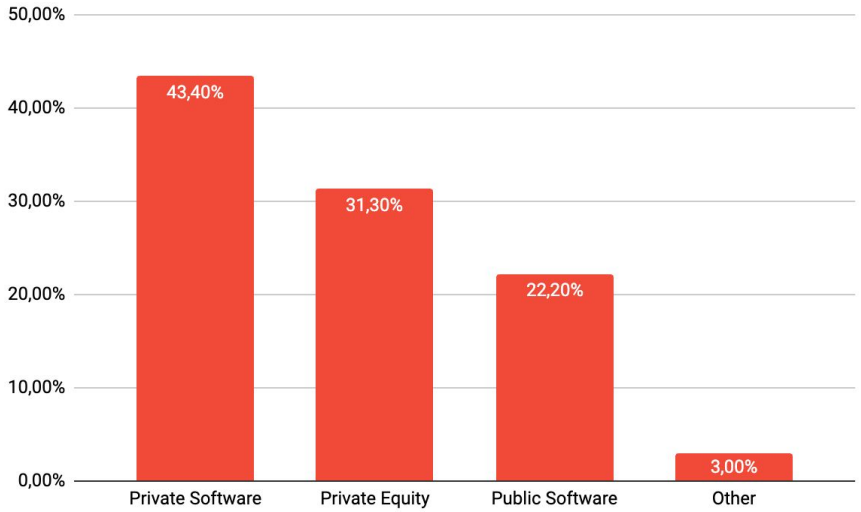


NORTH AMERICAN COMPANIES ARE THE MOST ACQUISITIVE IN COSS WHILE *PRIVATELY OWNED* SOFTWARE COMPANIES UNDERTOOK 43% OF ALL HISTORICAL M&A

COSS Acquirers by HQ Location



COSS Acquirers by Typology



Source: PitchBook & Public Data

Q: WHO ARE THE MOST ACTIVE ACQUIRERS OF COSS COMPANIES?

THE MOST *ACTIVE* COSS ACQUIRERS SINCE 2000



F5 Networks
(Public Software)

Nginx ($670M-2019)
Suborbital (undisclosed-2023)



VMware
(Public Software before Acquisition)

Pivotal Software ($2.7Bn-2019)
Ncira Networks ($1.2Bn-2012)
Heptio ($420M-2018)
Bitnami (undisclosed-2019)



Thoma Bravo
(Private Equity)

ForgeRock ($6.4Bn-2023)
Talend ($2.4Bn-2021)
Alfresco Software (undisclosed-2020)
Instructure (undisclosed-2020)



IBM
(Public Software)

RedHat ($34Bn-2019)
HashiCorp ($6.4Bn-2024)
Databand ($150M-2022)
Ahana (undisclosed-2023)
Kubecost (undisclosed-2024)



Snowflake
(Public Software)

Streamlit ($800M-2022)
Ponder ($46M-2023)



EQT Partners
(Private Equity)

SUSE ($2.5Bn-2018)
WSO2 ($600M-2024)



Red Hat
(Public Software before Acquisition)

JBoss ($420M-2006)
CoreOS ($250M-2018)
Gluster ($138M-2012)
NeuralMagic (undisclosed-2024)



Databricks
(Private Software)

MosaicML ($1.3Bn-2023)
Tabular ($1Bn-2024)

Source: PitchBook Data

THE POV



Jon Jones
VP @Global Head
of Startups @AWS

aws

HQ: US

Across the world, the momentum around open-source innovation is undeniable. Open-source startups are fundamental to the tech ecosystem—they democratize access to cutting-edge technologies, foster unprecedented transparency, drive collaborative problem-solving across industries.

For startups leveraging AI today, three critical needs stand out: they require model flexibility to adapt to specific use cases, transparency to understand and trust their AI systems' decisions, and sovereignty over their data and technology stack—all while moving at startup speed without getting bogged down in infrastructure management.

AWS is here to make that journey easier, and to support the next wave of startup champions. With Amazon Bedrock, startups have choice to build on the state-of-the-art open models that best fit their purpose, integrate them seamlessly into their stack, and scale with confidence— all without the operational burden of managing the underlying infrastructure. This level of flexibility enables them to stay nimble, iterate fast, retain full control over their technology choices, and to focus on their core differentiation rather than undifferentiated heavy lifting.

Q: WHAT ARE THE ACQUISITIONS THAT MADE HEADLINES IN 2024?

THE 6 BIGGEST M&A COSS *DEALS* 2024

HashiCorp	INSTRUCTURE	BLACKDUCK	Tabular	ISOVALENT	WSO2
$6.4Bn	$4.8Bn	$2.1Bn	$1Bn	$650M	$600M

HashiCorp

Acquirer: IBM
Nature of Acquisition: M&A (public-to-public)

Category: Core infrastructure/ Back-end/Devops

Instructure

Acquirer: KKR & Dragoneer
Nature of Acquisition: LBO (public-to-public)

Category: Business Application

BlackDuck

Acquirer: Clearlake Capital Group & Francisco Partners
Nature of Acquisition: LBO

Category: Security

Tabular

Acquirer: Databricks
Nature of Acquisition: M&A

Category: Data

Isovalent

Acquirer: Cisco Systems
Nature of Acquisition: M&A

Category: Core infrastructure/ Back-end/Devops

WSO2

Acquirer: EQT Partners
Nature of Acquisition: M&A

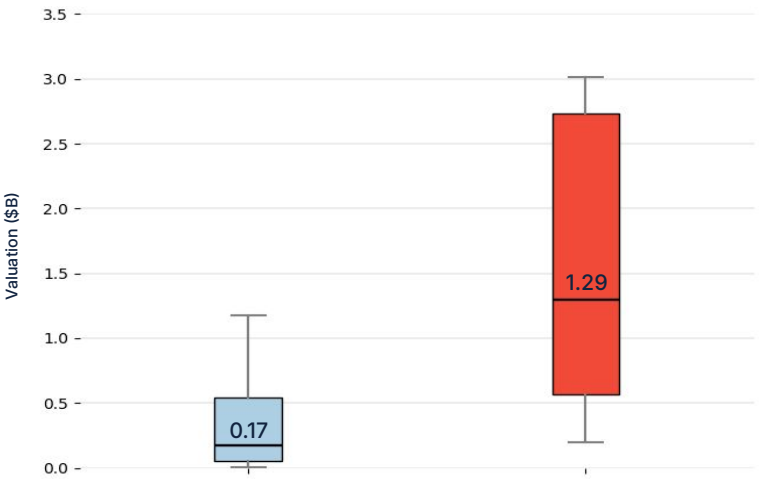
Category: Core infrastructure/ Back-end/Devops

Source: PitchBook & Public Data

COSS COMPANIES EXIT AT BETTER VALUATIONS THAN THEIR CLOSED SOURCES *COUNTERPARTS*

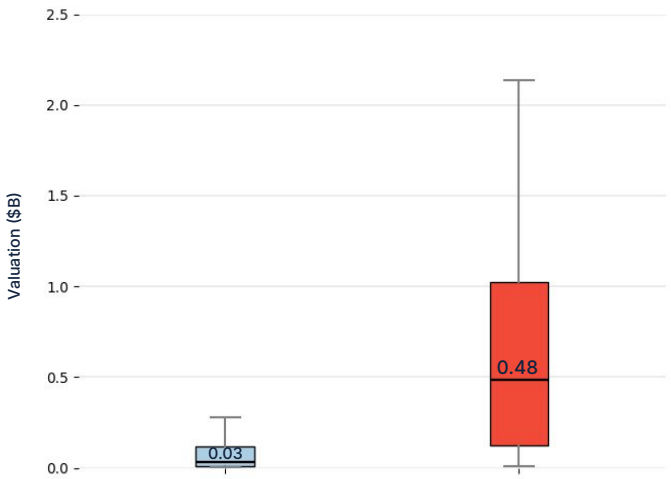
Valuation @ IPO

p-value : 0.000003



Valuation @ M&A

p-value : 0.000000



Closed-source Open-source

Liquidity timelines show no major difference between COSS and closed-source companies for M&A (median time: 5 years for both).

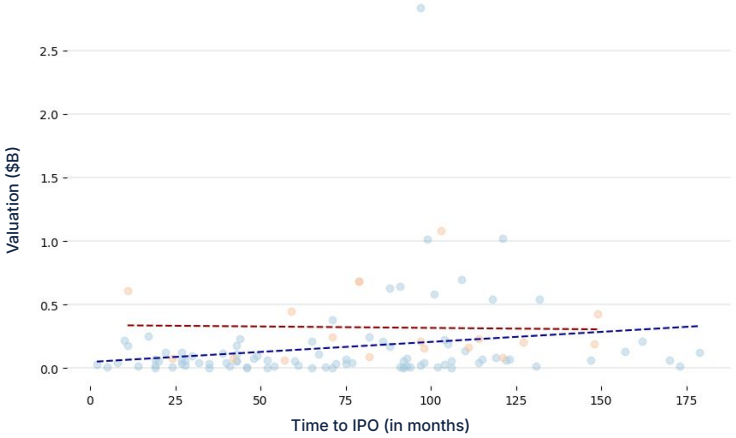
For IPOs, COSS companies historically took longer to go public - 8 years vs. 5.6 years for the broader software category.

Methodology: We compared deal sizes at M&A and pre-money valuations at IPO for infrastructure companies across the COSS and control software datasets (US, Canad, Europe, VC-backed or formerly VC-backed) using Mann-Whitney tests to assess statistical significance.

IPO: NO EVIDENCE COSS REQUIRE MORE TIME OR CAPITAL TO ACHIEVE SIMILAR VALUATIONS

Time to IPO and Valuations

R^2 Control Group : 0.030
R^2 COSS : 0.000

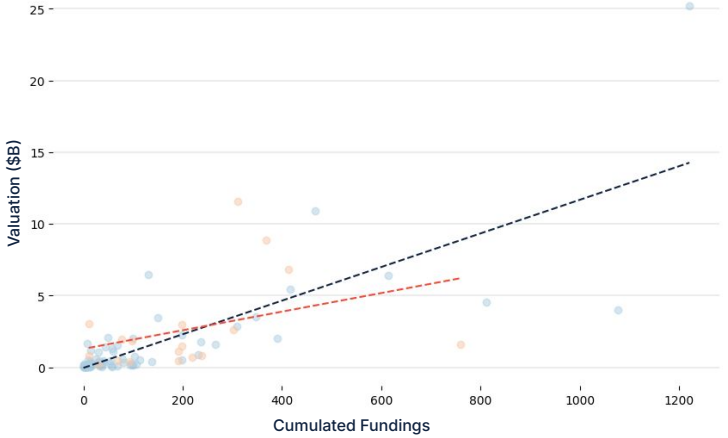


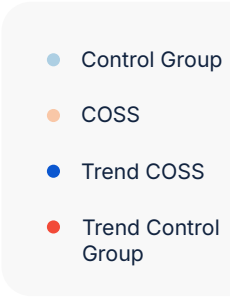
COSS companies do not systematically take longer (or shorter) to IPO compared to closed-source companies for a given level of valuation.

Indeed valuation and time to IPO are essentially uncorrelated (very low R^2), and the COSS and control group trends are statistically indistinguishable (p = 0.6041).

Cum. Fundings and Valuations

R^2 Control Group : 0.633
R^2 COSS : 0.137





COSS Companies do not systematically require more or less capital to achieve a given IPO valuation compared to closed-source companies.

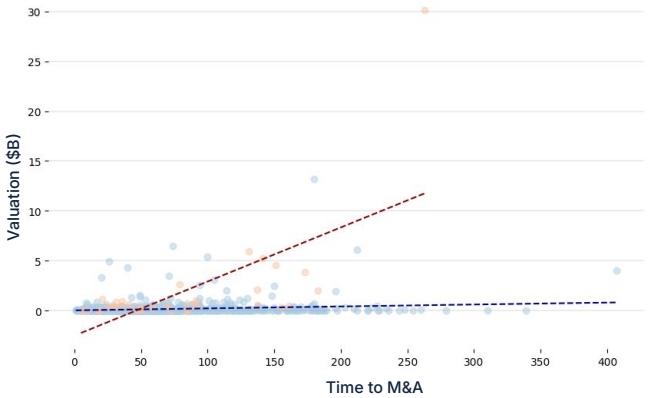
Valuation and cumulative funding are only weakly correlated for COSS companies (R^2 = 0.137), while the correlation is much stronger for the control group (R^2 = 0.633). However, the difference in funding efficiency — the relationship between funding raised and valuation achieved — is not statistically significant (p = 0.2134).

Source: PitchBook Data

COSS COMPANIES COMMAND HIGHER STRATEGIC VALUE IN ACQUISITIONS

Time to M&A and Valuations

R^2 Control Group : 0.023
R^2 COSS : 0.417

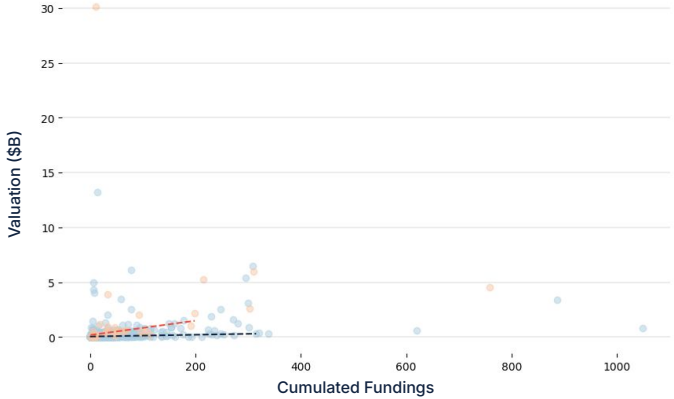


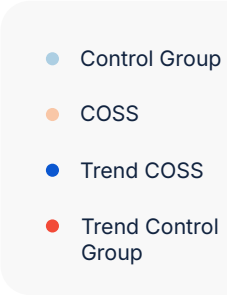
For a given time to M&A, COSS companies achieve significantly higher valuations compared to closed-source companies.

COSS R^2 (time-to-valuation correlation): 0.417 vs. Control Group: 0.023, showing that valuation compounds more predictably over time for COSS.
COSS time efficiency (slope): 54.2 vs. Control: 1.94, meaning that longer time to M&A translates into significantly higher deal sizes for COSS, unlike closed-source companies.
The statistically significant difference (p = 0.0000) confirms that COSS companies benefit from compounding value over time, whereas time plays little role in closed-source exits.

Cum. Fundings and Valuations

R^2 Control Group : 0.129
R^2 COSS : 0.401





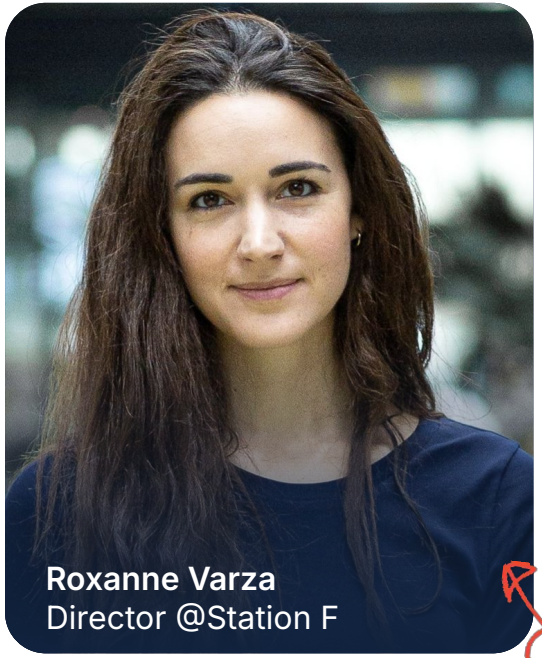
For a given amount of capital raised, COSS companies achieve significantly higher valuations at M&A compared to closed-source companies.

COSS R^2 (capital-to-valuation correlation): 0.401 vs. Control Group: 0.129, indicating that cumulative funding explains valuations more effectively for COSS.
COSS capital efficiency (slope): 6.55 vs. Control: 0.81—meaning each dollar raised contributes more to final valuation in COSS.
This statistically significant difference (p = 0.0001) confirms that COSS companies extract more value per dollar raised than closed-source companies.

Source: PitchBook Data

TESTIMONIAL

THE POV



Roxanne Varza
Director @Station F

STATION F

HQ: France

At STATION F, and in France more generally, we are observing a rapid adoption of open source - which is transforming the tech industry and collaboration alike.

We've seen an especially big impact with generative AI. Startups like Hugging Face, a STATION F company, play a major role in democratizing and fostering open source.

We believe that open source is a real opportunity for innovation, but not without risks; security, governance, IP protection are some of the points that require specific attention.

That said, the future of open source can greatly benefit the entire ecosystem and we are thrilled to see its growth.

serena

ABOUT SERENA

serena

Serena is one of Europe's leading venture capital funds, with 1 billion euros under management.

In February 2025, the fund was recognized among the Top 5% value-add seed investors by Dealroom.

Founded in 2008, Serena invests at early stages, from seed to series A, and supports innovative and ambitious entrepreneurs' success to serve a better world. Born of the profound conviction that a venture capital fund should be at the service of its portfolio companies, Serena has set up the largest operational platform team in Europe and the most active startup community, the Serena Squad, with more than 550 active C-levels.

Serena strongly focuses on AI, SaaS, Climate Tech, Deep Tech, and Impact. Serena has invested in more than 100 startups with several international success stories such as Dataiku, Malt, The Fork, Electra, Descartes Underwriting, Accenta, Lifen, and AramisAuto. Combating climate change, protecting biodiversity, promoting sustainability, diversity and inclusion are at the heart of Serena's DNA.

WE *BACKED* 100+ COMPANIES INCLUDING:

data iku · malt · ACINQ · OpsMill · CybelAngel · sarus · pyannoteAI

KILI TECHNOLOGY · TheFork · iBanFirst · implicity · POWDER · COMETH

ELECTRA · LAUNCHMETRICS · DESCARTES · lifen · Acheel · Memo Bank

mindee · switstack · Lokki · odaseva · kotzilla · inato

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